

Seeking the common good: Aquinas's Approach to Reconciling Aristotle and Christianity

During the 12th century, Averroes translates some of Aristotle's work in Arabic and pushes his doctrines forward in dialogue with the Islamic intellectual world that acts as a guardian of ancient Greek knowledge after most of it is destroyed and made unavailable to western Europe. During the next century, exchanges with the byzantine empire gradually reintroduces Aristotle to western Europe until Aquinas translates his works to Latin and adapts them to the context of his time; a world of Christianity and Roman legal heritage. In this paper, I will argue that despite the apparent divergence between Aristotle and Christianity, Aquinas is successful in reconciling the pair beyond their conflict. I will support this statement by bringing to attention how Aquinas makes them interact through natural law, the notion of common good, and slavery. To do so, I will first examine the role of rational creatures in eternal law, then compare reason and obedience as paths to virtue.

First of all, I will consider the role of rational thinking in the order of law by looking at how it fits with eternal law and then Christian doctrine more broadly. Aquinas distinguishes 4

kinds of laws: a legal system made by men called human law, and a legal system God made for the universe, called eternal law, made of 2 parts: divine law or God's rules, and a set of observable eternal laws called natural law. It is regarding this last category that Aquinas solicited Aristotle's observations the most. Indeed, his conception of the use of reason is referred to by Aquinas as a mean to explain virtue, and the success of his enterprise is the evidence of natural law, depicted as the rules discoverable by human reason required to order our behavior for the purpose of living well. This is where the combined influence of Christianity and Greek thinking is revealed: Aquinas reinvents the Aristotelian ideas of living well and human ends as the will of God for us. Tracing its roots back to Aristotle's *Politics*, this concern with living the best life was not one the Church had at first, but slowly grew to be. It proved necessary to implement such ideas as the role of the Church became increasingly politicized and meant it had to reflect its new approach on its ongoing doctrine. Therefore, when Aquinas states that Aristotle's work can help theology because it helps understand more clearly God's plan for his creation to be virtuous, it is an opportunity for the new doctrine to emphasize the role of rational creatures in eternal law.

Here, I argue that there are incompatibilities between eternal and human law that lessen the role and success of rational actors. Our knowledge and understanding of eternal law is imperfect (Dyson 2002, p.88), so we need more precise rules pertaining to independent human affairs to apply it to particular human cases. Moreover, human law ought to be revisited constantly to adapt eternal law to the local needs and circumstances and to adjust to the short-lived nature of men. However, Aquinas also lays out a number of limits to human law, such as arbitrary rule arising from contrary judgement, failing to account for essentially virtuous internalized actions, and reducing the good through the increase of punishment (Dyson 2002, p.90). To address these shortcomings, human law needs to be directed by divine law and only participates in right reason

when guided by divine reason. As the law of God applies to all His children yet the law of men only applies to those among them with reason. Undoubtedly, religious arguments invoking the higher nature of laws indecipherable by men is not something in line with Aristotle's attempt at explaining the world around him through reason. Here, Christianity seems to put a limit to the reasoning capacities of a human and show our lesser role in the face of eternal law.

Now, I will discuss the mechanisms used by Aquinas to operate this alliance between Aristotle and Christianity. It appears he cements the relation of the Greek thinker and Christianity with legislature as a middle ground allowing them to reinforce each other. By establishing natural law as the rules discoverable by human reason and as part of Catholic teachings, ordering our behavior for the purpose of living well is, an Aristotelian feat, is retrieved by Aquinas that incorporates it to Catholicism. The center of the alchemy operated in the *Political Writings* is in fact making sure that the idea of lawfulness, or *Ius*, operates on an assumption of being governed by reason and directed at the final end of humans being happiness. In other terms; establishing Aristotle's ideas as a model of what ought to be pursued and ensuring its legitimacy by affirming it aligns with the principles presented in Catholic philosophy allows Aquinas to reconcile the two. If this idea seems traditionally conventional coming from a Christian author, how can we explain that he was the one introducing the idea that doing good in the world is worthy in some meaningful sense in God's eyes? The promotion of all virtue and condemnation of all sins is a common theme throughout the *Political Writings*, and its author does so to incorporate the merit of a virtuous life as holy. Based on provided arguments, it is now clear that Aquinas effectively bridges the gap between Aristotle and Christianity by weaving together their respective philosophical frameworks within the context of law and virtue.

Secondly, let us now look into how successful the integration of reason to attain virtue in the catholic doctrine is. One could argue that the centrality of reason in the rule of law can be questioned: the application of human law only requires the usage of philosophical reasoning in the minds of authorities to rule interpersonal relationships. Contextually, the Church did not have any incentives to suddenly encourage its followers to develop independent thinking by internalizing the ideas of a pre-Christian thinker. Nor did it seem relevant to promote such ideas if they led to a state of self-realization of fulfilment on which the Church had no influence. It seems such position would be disastrous for the standing and influence of the Church that would then be deemed obsolete. But there is another answer, which is the very reason Aquinas is writing from the start: the cultivation of virtue. It is in that principle that lays the fundamental similarity of Christianity and Greek philosophy: the means to attaining the final end of men. On governments, Aquinas said the ruling of a country is comparable to steering a ship: it needs not only to be carefully preserved but also to be guided towards its destination, its final end (Dyson 2002, p.10). There exist different paths to reach that goal however, and Aristotle's one seems to differ from the catholic one: when the first preaches reasoning, the second commands obedience. In light of this difference, we will now delve into the application of virtue to these approaches.

Then, I argue that the formation of human law through obedience can obstruct the role of reason in virtue. There are multiple ways of inducing virtue in a society, and it seems a standardized method can be more efficient than self-enlightenment through reason. Indeed, the time-consuming task of adapting the good life's teachings to each person's complex individuality appears to be a tedious process. Instead, the mental exercise of understanding one's end through reason can be done only once with its result and the necessary steps towards its completion shared with others under the form of human laws. The orderliness of this proposition is twofold: by giving

the initial task to an already virtuous or a set of virtuous men, the validity and righteousness of the common end they will come to is beneficial to all. Secondly, the act of extracting from natural law the rules which will guide not only a man but a community also achieves the purpose of human activity, which is the common good of the community. Nonetheless, natural law is not the only set of rules Aquinas wants governments to pay attention to when making human laws for the common good; as the whole universe is governed by divine reason (Dyson 2002, p.84) which forms divine law, itself being the rest of eternal law, deciphering the sacred texts and God's mysterious intents through them is just as important, if not more, to form a lawful and virtuous community.

After having examined both modes of virtue, I will now delve into the reconciliation of this paths of virtue through the examination of slavery. The question that now seems to arise is if Aquinas' understanding of obedience as a means to attain common good is compatible with Aristotle's legacy of using reason for the same goal. To get a clear grasp on both stances on the matter, let us delve into their position for a separate instance that should still unveil the methodology of their arguments. Aristotle argues against the unjust practice of slavery, and identifies natural slaves whose bodies rule over their souls making it their best interest to find another person's soul (a master) under whom work, justifying their enslavement (Simpson 1997, 1260a33). On the other hand, the medieval Christian doctrine dictates that if we could think humans are born equal, we see in practice many inequalities between them establishing that these differences are natural. However, as natural things proceed from natural power and superior beings move inferior ones by will (Dyson 2002, p.58), a social edifice similar to Aristotle's arises from these conjectures, ordering human relations according to the natural disposition of their actor. In these terms, virtue is dual as it manifests in the ability of the rulers to bring about good for their subordinates, but also in the obedience of the ruled when carrying out a command (Dyson 2002,

p.98). In other words, reason is useful to rulers the same way obedience is useful to his subjects, and the relationship of the two takes the shape of the rule of law, showing the compatibility of both in attaining the common good.

In conclusion, the integration of Aristotle's philosophy into Christian doctrine, as facilitated by Aquinas, represents a significant milestone in the history of Western thought. Through examining the role of rational creatures in eternal law, comparing reason and obedience as paths to virtue, and exploring the reconciliation of these paths through examples such as slavery, this paper has demonstrated the successful alignment of Aristotelian principles with Christian theology. Aquinas's synthesis not only bridges apparent divergences between the two traditions but also enriches our understanding of virtue and the common good. Overall, this essay highlights the enduring relevance of ancient philosophy in shaping ethical and political discourse within the context of religious thought.

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Arthur Barrier